

ENDING

How a text chooses to finish



1 What is it?

Ending

The ending is how a writer **chooses to close** a text — it's the last thing a reader experiences, so it shapes how the whole piece is remembered.

final lines = lasting impression

2 See it in action

Resolution

Tying up loose ends so the reader feels satisfied and complete.

Cliffhanger

Cutting off at a tense, unresolved moment to leave the reader wanting more.

Twist

Revealing something unexpected that changes how the whole story is understood.

Circular ending

Returning to an image or line from the opening, but with new meaning.



Look here!

Compare the **final lines to the opening lines** — a deliberate echo (same word, image or setting) is a powerful structural technique worth flagging.

FUN FACT

A "circular structure" ending (returning to the opening) is one of the most highly-rewarded structural techniques in exam analysis, because it shows the **WHOLE** text was carefully planned, not just the final paragraph.

3 Why writers use it

Ending helps writers: leave the reader with a specific feeling (satisfaction, unease, hope), reward or subvert what the opening promised, and make the whole text feel deliberately shaped rather than just stopping.

The ending is often where a writer's real message sits — because it's the last thing read, it carries extra weight in shaping the reader's overall interpretation.

4 Where you'll spot it

Films & TV

A cliffhanger ending is a deliberate structural choice to make you want the next episode.

Persuasive speeches

Endings often circle back to the opening line for a powerful, memorable close.



Watch out!

Don't assume every ending "wraps everything up" — an unresolved or ambiguous ending is often a deliberate choice, not a missing piece.



You got this!

Ask: **does this ending answer the question the opening raised, or deliberately leave it open?** Both are valid choices — name which one it is.

5 Quick recap

The text's final lines

Shapes the lasting impression

Can resolve, twist, or leave things open



Good spot!

Try writing two different endings for the same short scene — one that resolves everything, one that cuts off mid-tension. Notice the very different feeling each leaves.